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Political lines are blurring at DOJ

US attorney general's appearances at GOP rallies draw scrutiny

By Alanna Durkin Richer
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — Attorney General Todd Blanche is blurring traditional boundaries between politics and federal law enforcement with recent speeches at political events that mark a sharp departure from norms meant to protect the Justice Department from the appearance of partisan bias.

Blanche took the stage this week at an event for a Republican Senate candidate in North Carolina days after speaking at a GOP midterm convention, where he praised Trump and touted the administration's tough-on-crime approach.

Blanche's participation at the rallies has drawn scrutiny from critics who say it threatens to undermine public faith in law enforcement decisions that are supposed to be made free of political interference. It has added to critics' concerns about Blanche's loyalty to Trump and White House influence on Justice Department matters against the backdrop of investigations into numerous perceived foes of the president.

"It lends credence to the arguments that the Justice Department is hopelessly politicized," said Richard Painter, who was a White House ethics lawyer in the George W. Bush administration. "And that's not where we want to be right now."

Attorneys general have typically stayed away from political rallies and at arm's length from

See **DOJ** on Page A2



Ann Caruso, center right, yells in response to a panel member's statement during the question-and-answer segment of a community meeting to discuss a proposed Amtrak maintenance facility in the Bridgeport neighborhood of Chicago on Thursday. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Feeling railroaded?

Crowd calls plan for Amtrak maintenance yard near Rate Field ‘nasty real estate deal’

By Brian J. Rogal
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

An overflow crowd packed into a South Side union training hall Thursday night and loudly rejected the plan sketched out by Amtrak officials for a massive new maintenance center in their neighborhood.

The company's presentation was punctuated by boos and groans from hundreds of Chinatown, Bridgeport and Armour Square residents.

Most people said they worried about potential pollution. Many also complained the surrounding

communities were not consulted, and that they first heard about the project in August when Amtrak announced it secured nearly \$700 million in federal loans to develop the facility.

"This kind of facility does not belong in a residential neighborhood, period," said Elizabeth Riddle. "We are not accepting this. We will continue to fight."

Amtrak's proposed maintenance yard would stretch for about 2 miles along Canal Street between Cermak Road and 38th Street on the current Union Pacific railyard just west of the Chicago White Sox's Rate Field. The plan includes a multi-

story train shed, a train washing facility and other storage areas. It would replace Amtrak's current railyard along the South Branch of the Chicago River at 14th Street, just across from The 78, a mixed-use development and site of the Chicago Fire's new stadium.

Steven Segerlin, Amtrak's head of commercial development, said the company held a series of community meetings in Chinatown starting this summer and will hold others in the affected communities as the \$900 million project moves forward.

See **AMTRAK** on Page A4

TRADING THE SOX FOR SERVICE YARD?

Canal Edge, a company controlled by billionaire Justin Ishbia, a minority owner of the White Sox who could purchase majority ownership in the future, was selected to develop Amtrak's new facility. Ishbia is kicking in \$125 million toward the project. Earlier this month he also unveiled plans for a new riverfront Sox park on Amtrak's current site near 14th Street.



Students in racist taunting withdraw from Lincoln-Way

By Olivia Stevens
DAILY SOUTHTOWN

Lincoln-Way High School District 210 board members will allow six students who engaged in racist taunting of Homewood-Flossmoor High School community members during a football game Sept. 4 to voluntarily withdraw from the district, after voting unanimously on the matter Thursday.

"This investigation, which involved interviewing numerous students, reviewing multiple video recordings and angles, and speaking with their attorneys, took the administration only eight school days, and ultimately resulted in the administration

recommending expulsion for the students determined to have been involved," District 210 Superintendent Scott Tingley said.

He said the students' parents chose to voluntarily withdraw their children, forfeiting all student privileges, rather than continue with the process.

The decision followed a walk-out at Lincoln-Way East where about 50 students protested the racist taunting by their peers at the football game against H-F, along with similar actions alleged at a girls cross-country meet the following day.

Tingley said he was confident the matter was handled

See **STUDENTS** on Page A6

"Our children don't feel safe in their communities, and if your children cannot do what they need to do when they come to our side of town, keep them here."

SEQUOIA WILLIAMS, of Country Club Hills, who said allowing the six students to withdraw sidesteps accountability

‘THE SPIRIT IS STILL THE SAME’

Cristo Rey Jesuit High School hits 30 years, offers work-study education

Students walk to an assembly in the gym at Cristo Rey Jesuit High School in Chicago on Tuesday. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

By Kate Perez | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The passing periods of Cristo Rey Jesuit High School come without sound. With seemingly no warning, the Pilsen school's students rise from their desks and chairs, lunch tables and benches, and head to their next destination, an internal clock running in their brains instead of a bell.

It's a practice rooted in the school's desire to teach responsibility and independence, a hope that students will carry that self-sufficiency into the workplace.

Students, dressed as required in business casual to reflect the lives they're training to lead, move easily through the uncrowded hallways. Monday through Thursday, roughly a quarter of the students — or one grade level — are scattered across Chicagoland at work-study positions in law firms, hospitals and investment banking

See **SPIRIT** on Page A4



CHRIS SWEDA/TRIBUNE

SPORTS It's ride or die for Sox bullpen

The White Sox's strength for most of this crazy season has been their bullpen depth, and if they're going to survive this late-September stretch run, manager Will Venable needs the relievers to continue to do the heavy lifting.

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WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H:75 L: 66
SUN. H:70 L: 60
MON. H:64 L: 55

FULL WEATHER REPORT A8

INDEX

Almanac A6
Arts & Living B7
Comics B10-11

Crossword B11
Editorials A5
Horoscope B10

Nation & World B4
Sudoku B11
Television B9

179th year No. 262
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7 49485 00001 2